

Milk Before Meat — Honest Review Against Church Concerns

A working briefing to read before approaching priesthood leaders. This is the foundation document: it lists every legitimate concern a thoughtful bishop or Church leader could raise, and answers each one plainly and honestly — using what the app actually does, and what the Church has actually published. Nothing here is spin. The goal is not to make the app “impossible to refute”; it is to be so transparent that a careful leader can give an informed yes.

HOW TO USE THIS DOCUMENT

Do not hand this whole document to the Bishop — it is your briefing, so that when a question comes up, you already know the honest answer and the source behind it. The polished one-page **Bishop Brochure** is what you hand him. This is what makes you calm and unsurprised in the room.

A note on posture, because it matters more than any single answer: you are not bringing this to be argued into acceptance. You are bringing it humbly, for his counsel and his blessing to test it locally, and you are genuinely willing to hear “not yet” or “change this first.” That posture is itself the strongest thing you can carry in. A leader relaxes when he sees you are not trying to win — you are trying to do this right.

THE CHURCH’S OWN PUBLISHED GUIDANCE (YOUR ANCHOR POINTS)

Three published Church positions matter most here, and the good news is that the app was already built in line with all three.

1. The General Handbook’s guidance on artificial intelligence (added December 2025). The Church teaches that if members use AI, they should do so “in positive, helpful, and uplifting ways” that uphold the Church’s integrity and teachings; that AI “cannot replace the gift of divine inspiration or the individual work required to receive it”; that “interactions with AI cannot substitute for meaningful relationships with God and others”; and that sensitive personal data should be handled with care. The Church’s stated aim is to use AI “to support and not supplant connection between God and His children.”

2. The Church’s trademark and name guidance. The full name of the Church, as well as “Mormon” and “LDS,” are protected. Members may not use them in a way that “suggests or implies” that a product is “endorsed by or affiliated with the Church or its leaders,” and these terms “should not be used in the name of an organization or product.”

3. The General Handbook on sharing the gospel (Chapter 23). Member missionary work is built on “love, share, and invite,” and the Handbook states plainly that “any effort to live the principles of love, share, and invite is positive, whether or not a person meets with the missionaries or joins the Church.”

Every concern below is answered against these three anchors.

CONCERN 1 — “DOES THIS LOOK LIKE AN OFFICIAL CHURCH PRODUCT? IS IT MISUSING THE CHURCH’S NAME?”

The honest answer: No, and the app is deliberately built to prevent that. The product is named “Milk Before Meat,” which uses none of the Church’s protected marks. Every time the app opens, and again on the profile screen, it shows a plain disclaimer: “*This app is not officially affiliated with, endorsed by, or sponsored by any church. It is an independent space to explore who Jesus is.*” The AI itself is instructed never to present itself as official, and to say plainly, when asked who made it, that it was made by members of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints — never implying institutional endorsement.

This lines up exactly with the Church’s trademark guidance, which asks members precisely not to imply endorsement or affiliation and not to put Church marks in a product name. The app does neither.

CONCERN 2 — “IS IT EVEN APPROPRIATE TO USE AI FOR SOMETHING THIS SACRED?”

The honest answer: The Church has now spoken to this directly, and the app was built to the same standard. The December 2025 Handbook guidance says AI should be used in positive, uplifting ways, should never replace divine inspiration or real relationships, and should support rather than supplant a person’s connection to God. The app is built on exactly that conviction. Every single time it opens, it tells the user — in one of several gentle variants — that it is “a lantern, not the Light,” that it cannot hear or answer a prayer, and that when they are ready to pray they should close the screen and speak directly to God. The app’s stated purpose, written into the AI’s core instructions, is to “point to Him” and “decrease so the Master is seen.”

It is worth naming for the Bishop that this is anchored in Elder Gerrit W. Gong’s own counsel that AI “can answer questions, but it cannot answer prayers... it is not God and cannot be God.” The app didn’t bolt that on as a defense; it was built around it.

The honest caveat to hold (do not hide it): The Church’s published AI guidance is written for *members using AI in their Church assignments*. An AI that ministers to seekers and investigators is newer ground that the Church has not specifically blessed or endorsed. That is exactly why you are bringing it through the priesthood line as an independent member’s pilot, seeking local guidance — not presenting it as something the Church has approved. Saying this out loud *increases* trust; it shows you understand the line you are standing near and are choosing to respect it.

CONCERN 3 — “COULD THE AI TEACH FALSE OR UNCORRELATED DOCTRINE?”

The honest answer: This is a real risk with any AI, and the app is built to minimize it — but you should name it openly, not deny it. By design the app gives “milk” only: it ministers from the Bible and the goodness of God that a person already accepts, and it is explicitly forbidden from introducing the Restoration, Joseph Smith, the Book of Mormon, or latter-day prophets unless the person both believes God is good *and* opens the door themselves — and even then it asks permission first. It is instructed to admit uncertainty plainly (“never bluff”) and to offer a real human rather than guess.

The honest part you should say plainly: this is not correlated Church curriculum, and like any large language model it could occasionally state something imprecisely. That is precisely what a careful, priesthood-supervised testing phase is *for*. You review the conversations; trusted priesthood holders test it and flag anything that feels off; nothing is presented as official doctrine. Framing the test this way turns the biggest worry into the very reason the test exists.

CONCERN 4 — “ISN’T ‘INVISIBLE ROUTING’ AND WAITING TO MENTION THE CHURCH A FORM OF MANIPULATION OR DECEPTION?”

The honest answer: This is the most important concern to meet head-on, calmly, and it has a real answer. The app never denies what it is. If a person asks “are you a bot?”, “who made this?”, or “is this an LDS app?”, the AI is instructed to tell the truth simply and immediately and *never* to conceal it. What it does not do is *open* with “I am here to convert you to my church” — for the same reason Jesus did not open with “I am the Messiah, follow me.” He told stories, healed, asked questions, and let people come to know Him through relationship and the Spirit. The app patterns itself on that: it meets the person where they are, and it lets the deeper truth unfold only as the person reaches for it and gives permission.

Two things make this honest rather than manipulative, and you should say both: first, the app discloses the moment it is asked — there is no lie anywhere in it. Second, it asks the person’s explicit permission before ever introducing the restored

gospel, and it drops the subject completely and warmly if they decline, “never letting the no cost them anything.” It leaves everyone free — its written rule is literally “Jesus let the rich young ruler walk away. So do you.”

If a leader still has reservations about the staged approach, that is a fair conversation to have — and the right response is openness, not defensiveness. You can say honestly: *this is exactly the kind of thing I want priesthood eyes on during the test.*

CONCERN 5 — “WHAT ABOUT PRIVACY AND THE SENSITIVE THINGS PEOPLE MIGHT SHARE?”

The honest answer: The app collects little, ties nothing to a real identity by default, and lets people delete what it has learned. People are signed in anonymously — there is no name, email, or login required to use it. When someone chooses to reach a real human, their message is stored tied only to that anonymous ID, and they can only ever see their own conversation. On the profile screen, the app shows the person what it has noticed about them and gives them buttons to remove any of it. There is a published privacy policy at milk4meat.org.

The honest caveat: the conversation is processed by an outside AI provider (Anthropic), and the human-inbox messages are stored in a Google Firebase database. That is normal for an app like this, but it is true and you should not pretend the data lives nowhere. The Church’s fourth AI principle — be careful with sensitive personal data — is one you are honoring by minimizing what’s collected and letting users delete it, and it is another good reason to keep the testing pool small and trusted at first.

CONCERN 6 — “DOES THIS REPLACE MISSIONARIES, THE WARD, OR PROPER CHANNELS?”

The honest answer: No — it is one member living ‘love, share, invite,’ and it always points back to real people. The app is not a substitute for missionaries or the ward; it keeps a real human “one tap away” at every step, and its long-term vision explicitly includes real missionaries being integrated into the conversation later. Right now it is simply you, a member, doing what Chapter 23 describes — inviting people toward Christ — with a tool that hands them to a real person whenever they want one. And the Handbook’s own measure of success fits the app perfectly: the effort is positive “whether or not a person joins the Church.” The app’s written goal says the same thing in its own words: “A person who leaves unconverted but truly met, unpressured, and free is a success.”

CONCERN 7 — “WHAT IF SOMEONE IN CRISIS USES IT?”

The honest answer: The app has a deliberate, careful crisis protocol, and you can show it. If someone signals despair, self-harm, or acute crisis, the AI is instructed to lead with pure presence rather than a hand-off, to never act as a therapist or diagnose, to gently offer a real person, and — in the U.S., when there is sign of imminent danger — to surface the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline. This is a genuine duty-of-care design, and naming it to the Bishop shows you have thought about the hardest moments, not just the easy ones.

THE ONE-PARAGRAPH SUMMARY (SAY THIS IF YOU ONLY GET ONE MINUTE)

“It’s an independent app I built as a member — not a Church product, and it says so plainly every time it opens. It’s patterned on how the Savior actually ministered: meet people where they are, point them to the goodness of God, never pressure anyone, and keep a real person one tap away. It uses AI carefully and in line with the Handbook’s new AI guidance — it constantly reminds people it’s not God, can’t answer prayers, and that they should pray to Him directly. It never pretends to be official, never hides what it is when asked, and it leaves everyone completely free. I’m not asking the Church

to endorse it — I'm bringing it to you first, for your counsel and your blessing, to let a few trusted priesthood holders test it and tell me honestly what they see."